

The Desk: Brand Identity Guide

Version 2.0 / May 2026

Prepared for Ruben Laubscher, Head of Partnerships, InvestorKit

1. Brand Overview

The Desk is daily intelligence for the partner channel in Australian property. It delivers a 60-second morning scan at 7am AEST on weekdays and a long-form Weekly Edition every Sunday at 7am. Every story carries ready-to-use talking points so institutional partners, brokers, advisers and buyer's agents walk into client conversations sharper than the headlines. Written by Ruben Laubscher. Not a blog. Not marketing. Not generic finance content.

"No spam, no broadcast, just the stories I think a partner conversation should know about."

The aspirational register sits between The Information and Stratechery for voice, and a Bloomberg terminal for density. The job: read it before 8am, win the 10am call.

2. Logo System

The logo is the single most visible element of the brand. It must work at every size, from a 16px favicon to a conference banner, and communicate "editorial intelligence" at a glance without explanation.

2.1 Logo Concepts

Two refined directions are presented below. Both retain the amber-on-navy palette that defines The Desk and are designed to work at all sizes.

Concept A: The D-Sunrise

A stylised uppercase letter "D" where the vertical stroke is a thin editorial rule line and the curved stroke forms a rising sun arc with radiating lines. The concept ties directly to the existing "sunrise on the desk" metaphor but makes it legible as a letterform. The sun rays inside the bowl of the D communicate illumination and intelligence. At favicon size (16px), the mark reads as a distinctive D-shape rather than a generic dot.

Variant	Description	Use
---------	-------------	-----

Dark mark	Amber gold on navy	Primary. Favicon, app icon, social avatars, nav chrome
Light mark	Navy on warm cream	Light mode, printed materials, partner decks
Lockup	Mark + "The Desk" wordmark + "INTELLIGENCE" byline	Headers, hero sections, email signatures, OG images
Avatar crop	Mark centred in navy circle	LinkedIn, X/Twitter, all social profiles
OG card	Full lockup on navy with geometric texture	Link preview cards when sharing stories

Concept B: The TD Monogram

A geometric monogram combining the letters "T" and "D" into a single unified mark. The horizontal bar of the T doubles as a desk surface or editorial rule line. The D curves beneath, sharing the vertical stroke. The concept is clean, modern, and the simplest of all directions explored. It reads immediately at any size and does not require explanation.

Variant	Description	Use
Dark mark	Amber gold on navy	Primary. Favicon, app icon, social avatars, nav chrome
Light mark	Navy on warm cream	Light mode, printed materials, partner decks
Lockup	Mark + "The Desk" wordmark + "INTELLIGENCE" byline	Headers, hero sections, email signatures, OG images
Avatar crop	Mark centred in navy circle	LinkedIn, X/Twitter, all social profiles
OG card	Full lockup on navy with geometric texture	Link preview cards when sharing stories

2.2 Logo Usage Rules

These rules apply regardless of which concept is selected.

Clear space. Minimum padding around the lockup is equal to the cap-height of the wordmark (approximately 0.66 times the logomark height). At a 32px mark, the wordmark

is approximately 21px, so clear space is approximately 20px on every side. Nothing else, type or graphic, sits inside that zone.

Minimum size. Logomark alone: 20px. Brand lockup: 24px mark with 16px wordmark. Below these thresholds, the mark loses legibility.

Backgrounds. The lockup is built for dark surfaces (navy canvas and elevated panels). On the warm paper light-mode canvas, the wordmark gradient pulls deeper amber automatically. Avoid placing the lockup directly on amber: the wordmark gradient washes out and the kicker rule disappears. If you need it on amber, use the mark only and switch the strokes to navy.

What not to do:

Rule	Reason
Do not recolour the wordmark	The amber gradient is the identity
Do not separate the mark from the wordmark in standard usage	The lockup is the canonical surface
Do not change the byline	"INTELLIGENCE" is the only byline
Do not add a tagline strip under the lockup	The byline is the brand's only sub-mark text
Do not apply drop shadow, glow, or stroke to the lockup	The animated first-paint sequence is the only effect
Do not stretch, compress, or rotate	The geometry is exact
Do not substitute Playfair for another serif on the wordmark	Playfair Display is non-negotiable

2.3 Required Export Package

For public launch, the following files must exist as standalone exports, not just as React components.

File	Format	Sizes
Logomark (dark)	SVG + PNG	512, 256, 128, 64, 32, 16
Logomark (light)	SVG + PNG	512, 256, 128, 64, 32, 16
Logomark (mono white)	SVG + PNG	512, 256, 128, 64
Logomark (mono black)	SVG + PNG	512, 256, 128, 64

Brand lockup (dark)	SVG + PNG	1200w, 600w, 300w
Brand lockup (light)	SVG + PNG	1200w, 600w, 300w
Social avatar (circle crop)	PNG	400x400, 200x200
OG image template	PNG	1200x630
Favicon	ICO + PNG	32x32, 16x16
Apple touch icon	PNG	180x180

3. Colour System

The canvas is editorial broadsheet. Deep navy with amber as the defining accent. Every token lives in `client/src/index.css` . Do not invent new ones. If you need a new value, add it to the `@theme` block and use the token everywhere.

3.1 Core Palette

Token	OKLCH Value (Dark)	Hex Approximation	Role
<code>--color-bg</code>	<code>oklch(0.11 0.018 260)</code>	#0C1220	Page canvas. Near-black indigo.
<code>--color-bg-elevated</code>	<code>oklch(0.16 0.018 260)</code>	#141E30	Panel surfaces (cards, rail sections)
<code>--color-bg-deep</code>	<code>oklch(0.08 0.018 260)</code>	#060D18	The well beneath panels (footer, modal backdrops)
<code>--color-fg</code>	<code>oklch(0.94 0.005 80)</code>	#F0EDE8	Primary text. Warm off-white.
<code>--color-fg-muted</code>	<code>oklch(0.68 0.012 260)</code>	#9BA3B5	Body copy, dek text, secondary
<code>--color-fg-subtle</code>	<code>oklch(0.5 0.012 260)</code>	#6B7280	Captions, overlines, metadata only
<code>--color-amber</code>	<code>oklch(0.75 0.18 70)</code>	#D4A853	The brand accent. Editorial rule, focus rings, live dot, drop caps, CTA buttons

<code>--color-amber-bright</code>	<code>oklch(0.88 0.19 82)</code>	#F0C75E	Mid-stop on wordmark and CTA gradients
<code>--color-amber-dim</code>	<code>oklch(0.75 0.18 70 / 18%)</code>	#D4A853 at 18%	Amber washes, hover backgrounds, dim glows
<code>--color-ink</code>	<code>oklch(0.62 0.18 25)</code>	#B86B4A	Oxidised-copper secondary accent. Sparingly for callouts, directional deltas
<code>--color-border</code>	<code>oklch(1 0 0 / 9%)</code>	White at 9%	Hairline panel borders
<code>--color-border-strong</code>	<code>oklch(1 0 0 / 18%)</code>	White at 18%	Hover borders, structural rules

3.2 Light Mode Overrides

Light mode flips the canvas to warm off-white paper, pulls amber deeper so it does not blow out, and deepens every category accent. The key principle: if you find a hardcoded white-alpha that reads invisibly on paper, fix it in `index.css`, not at the component level.

Token	Light Value	Note
<code>--color-bg</code>	Warm cream (#F5F0E8)	Paper canvas
<code>--color-fg</code>	Near-black (#1A1A1A)	Dark text on light
<code>--color-amber</code>	<code>oklch(0.65 0.18 60)</code>	Deeper amber to maintain contrast

3.3 Category Accents

Nine editorial beats, each with its own hue. Used as a 2px left border on cards and as the overline colour on category labels.

Category	Hue	Rationale
PROPERTY	Green	Growth, land, building
MACRO	Amber	The brand accent, macro is the backbone

MARKETS	Orange	Energy, movement, trading floors
POLICY	Purple	Authority, governance
TECH	Blue	Digital, screens, precision
AI	Cyan	Distinct from Tech blue, futuristic
SCIENCE	Red	Discovery, urgency
ECONOMICS	Warm amber	Sibling to Macro, slightly warmer
GEOPOLITICS	Teal	Deliberately split from Policy purple so the two do not alias on the page
OTHER	Border-strong	No accent, neutral fallback

3.4 Persona Accents

Each persona has a distinguishing hue, defined once in `PERSONA_COLOUR` . These fire on the VIEW AS pill, the active row in Partner angles, the persona switcher chips, and the SayThis line.

Persona	OKLCH Value	Read
Institutional	<code>oklch(0.72 0.16 250)</code>	Institutional blue
Broker	<code>oklch(0.78 0.18 70)</code>	Amber (the brand accent)
Adviser	<code>oklch(0.72 0.17 155)</code>	Adviser green (shares hue with PROPERTY)
Buyers Agent	<code>oklch(0.62 0.18 25)</code>	Ink / oxidised copper (shares hue with <code>--color-ink</code>)

3.5 Gradients

Four canonical gradients, all tokenised. Do not write `linear-gradient()` inline. Reference the token.

Token	Use
-------	-----

<code>--grad-panel-soft</code>	The workhorse. Most panels with a fill use this.
<code>--grad-cta-deep</code>	Subscribe callout and big amber-bleed surfaces. Ends warm.
<code>--grad-modal-bg</code>	Radial amber bloom at top-right over panel-soft. Modals.
<code>--grad-hero-overlay</code>	Editorial wash over hero cover images.

Plus the wordmark gradient (`.wordmark` class). Three amber stops, applied to the Playfair "The Desk" lockup. The only place in the product that uses a true gradient on text.

4. Typography

Three faces. Pair them on purpose, never substitute.

4.1 Type Stack

Playfair Display (`--font-serif`). Display, headlines, key takeaways, drop caps, byline names. Tight tracking (`-0.028em` on h1 to h4, down to `-0.035em` on `display-1`). Bold weight (700) for headlines, italic for the dek under each topic title.

Source Sans 3 (`--font-sans`). Body copy. Loose tracking (`-0.011em`) and a generous 1.62 line-height. The page is built for reading, not skimming. Font-feature-settings `"ss01", "cv02", "cv11"` are on globally.

JetBrains Mono (`--font-mono`). Every overline, every label, every category badge, every CTA button, every tabular number. Wide tracking: `0.16em` on `overline-amber` , `0.18em` to `0.24em` on the various overline instances. 10 to 11px sizing. This is the editorial chrome of the product.

4.2 Display Scale

Class	Size	Tracking	Line-height	Use
<code>display-1</code>	<code>clamp(2.5rem, 6.5vw, 5rem)</code>	<code>-0.035em</code>	0.98	Hero only
<code>display-2</code>	<code>clamp(2rem, 4.5vw, 3.5rem)</code>	<code>-0.03em</code>	1.02	Section openers, edition number

display-3	clamp(1.5rem, 3vw, 2.25rem)	-0.025em	1.08	Topic titles
-----------	-----------------------------	----------	------	--------------

4.3 Type Pairing Rules

Context	Serif (Playfair)	Sans (Source Sans 3)	Mono (JetBrains)
Headline	Yes, Bold 700	No	No
Dek / subtitle	Yes, Italic	No	No
Body copy	No	Yes, Regular 400	No
Overline / label	No	No	Yes, 10-11px
CTA button text	No	No	Yes
Metric values	No	No	Yes, tabular
Byline name	Yes, Bold	No	No
Byline role	No	Yes, Muted	No

5. Voice and Tone

The single source of truth for voice is `server/prompts/voice.ts` . Every LLM generator in the product composes from `voiceRules` and `rubenSystemPrompt` so the register stays identical across the Daily Brief, Ruben's Take, sayThis lines, and partner-angle blocks.

5.1 Voice Principles

Calm authority, anti-noise. Ruben has watched markets long enough to see the patterns and refuses to perform certainty. If you reach for an intensifier, cut it.

Confident, not cocky. State the read. Do not justify it three times. Do not hedge it twice.

One intelligent person, not a crowd. Write like you are talking to a single broker over coffee. Never broadcast.

Non-obvious angle. Start from a counterintuitive observation. The obvious headline is what the reader already saw at 6am, which is precisely what they do not need from you.

Scene first, lesson last. Open with a specific moment, a number, a thing that happened. The thesis arrives after the scene.

Short sentences, then one longer one. Three or four short declaratives, then one longer analytical sentence that does the work. Then another short one to land it.

Close on a question, never a CTA. "Worth thinking about whether x." Not "Subscribe to find out more."

5.2 Do and Don't

Do	Don't
"The rate cut landed. Markets shrugged. The interesting thing is what brokers did the next morning."	"It's worth noting that the recent rate cut has created significant opportunities in the lending landscape."
"Three lenders pulled fixed rates this week. One did it quietly."	"Big news. Three major lenders just made a HUGE move on fixed rates."
"Sydney auction clearances held at 68%. The exposure isn't the headline, it's which suburbs carried the print."	"Sydney auction clearances remained robust at 68%, demonstrating resilient market dynamics."
"I keep coming back to this number."	"Let's dive into this fascinating data point."

5.3 Banned Words and Patterns

Em dashes, exclamation marks, bullet points in editorial output, emoji, hashtags, "leverage", "unlock", "seamless", "robust", "delve", "game-changer", "landscape", "cutting-edge", "it's worth noting", "in today's world", "let's dive in", "here's the thing", motivational language, corporate jargon, broadcast openings. Australian English throughout (colour, behaviour, organisation, realise).

6. Spacing and Layout

The product is built on Tailwind 4 defaults with a 4px base unit.

6.1 Spacing Scale

Token	Value	Typical Use
space-1	4px	Tight horizontal nudges (icon-to-label gaps)

space-2	8px	Inline cluster gap (chip rows, mono-label-to-value)
space-3	12px	Inter-element gap inside a card
space-4	16px	Default block gap
space-6	24px	Card padding (default)
space-8	32px	Section padding, large card padding
space-10	40px	Section-to-section vertical rhythm
space-12	48px	Major section separator

6.2 Panel Treatment

Panels carry a 1px border at `oklch(1 0 0 / 9%)` and an 8px backdrop blur. Hover variants lift to `border-strong` and warm the fill 8% toward white. Card lift on hover is 2px Y plus a deeper shadow. Apple-style, not theatrical.

Cards never have heavy radii. `rounded-sm` (2px corner radius, almost imperceptible). Pill chips use `rounded-full`. The deliberate friction is between the soft hairline and the otherwise rectilinear layout. It reads as broadsheet, not as web app.

6.3 The Editorial Rule

The defining horizontal element. A 1px amber-gradient line with a 14px glow, at the top of every page and under page headers. Lowered from a louder 2px in an earlier revision because it was competing with type.

7. Iconography

Icon family is **Lucide React** (`lucide-react@0.383.0`). Imported per-icon at the call site. Do not introduce a second icon family. Do not substitute emoji or Material icons.

Size Class	Pixels	Use
h-3 w-3	12px	Inline editorial chrome (live-dot, chevron in mono pills)

h-3.5 w-3.5	14px	Default chevron on collapsible headers, X close icons
h-4 w-4	16px	Standard inline icon (Mail, ExternalLink, LinkedIn)
h-8 w-8	32px	Hero chrome (CheckCircle2, Sparkles inside modal header)

Icons are coloured by inheritance from the parent text colour. Do not hard-code colours on icons unless the icon is also a state signal (such as the live-dot, where the amber is the message).

8. Motion

Motion is editorial. Apple-style, not theatrical. Every animation is named and has a clear job.

Choreographed, not chained. The first-paint sequence is a deliberate cascade: the mark fades in at 100ms, the editorial rule sweeps left-to-right at 250ms, content lifts at 500ms.

Slow over fast. Hero drift is 24 seconds. Specular shine is 14 seconds. Ticker is 70 seconds. The page is alive but never hurried.

One easing. Almost every transition uses `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`, an expressive-out curve. Fast leave, soft land.

Hover lift is 2px. Cards lift 2px on Y, deeper shadow, no amber wash on the ring. Premium-feeling, not theatrical.

Loading is shimmer. Skeleton placeholders use a 1.4s diagonal shimmer. Not a spinner. The page never goes blank.

Reduced motion. `@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce)` disables every long-running loop. Static state always works.

9. Imagery and Photography

Hero covers. Editorial illustrations and photography, authored dark. On the dark-mode page they sit at full opacity under a gradient wash so the hero text always reads. On light-mode the same illustrations get a brightness/contrast softening plus a lighter overlay, so they read as a textural backdrop rather than a black hole.

Ken Burns drift. Every hero cover animates with a 24-second slow scale and translation, plus a 14-second specular sweep. Subtle by design. Do not add zoom-on-scroll, parallax, or

any heavier motion.

Illustration style. Lean editorial-magazine, not stock-photo. Cinematic light. Deep shadows. Single subject. Avoid stock-photo tropes (laptop screens, handshakes, generic skylines).

10. Accessibility

Focus. `*:focus-visible` paints a 2px amber outline with 2px offset. Do not remove it on any interactive element.

Colour contrast. Dark mode primary text on canvas: 18.5:1 (WCAG AAA). Muted text: 7.4:1 (AAA for body). Subtle text: 3.7:1 (non-critical metadata only).

Reduced motion. All major animations honour `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce` .

Tap targets. 44x44 minimum on mobile. Chevron-toggles wrap the entire row, not just the icon.

11. Things The Desk Does Not Do

Negative space is half the brand. Cutting things keeps the rest sharp.

Rule	Reason
No clickbait headlines	No numbers in titles, no "you won't believe", no question-mark headlines the body does not answer
No broadcast tone	"Excited to share", "Thrilled to announce" are banned at the prompt level
No em dashes, no exclamation marks	A comma, a full stop, or rewrite the sentence
No emoji, no hashtags	Anywhere. Not in headlines, not in subject lines, not in the LinkedIn share strip
No motivational language	"Incredible", "exciting", "level up". The reader is a professional
No AI tells	"It's worth noting", "let's dive in", "game-changer", "landscape"
No bullet points in editorial prose	Exceptions only for structural scan patterns
No tracking pixels	The Desk offers an inbox, not a funnel

No CTAs at the close	End on a question that earns the next click without asking for it
No influencer voice	No "let me tell you", no "guys", no "here's the tea"
No second logo, no tagline crawls	The lockup is the lockup. The byline is "INTELLIGENCE". That is the whole surface.

12. Brand Collateral Checklist for Public Launch

The following items must be completed before The Desk goes public.

Item	Status	Notes
Logo concept selected	Done	Concept A (D-Sunrise) selected
SVG logo files (vector, scalable)	Done	14 SVGs: dark, light, mono-white, mono-black marks + horizontal and stacked lockups + favicon variant
PNG exports at all standard sizes	Done	95 files: marks at 512/256/128/64/32/16, square crops, navy-bg crops, lockups at 800w/400w/200w
Social avatar (LinkedIn, X)	Done	Circle crop on navy, 400x400, 200x200, 100x100
OG image template	Done	1200x630 vector-rendered + 2560x1440 AI-rendered
Favicon (ICO + PNG)	Done	ICO (16+32), standalone PNGs, simplified variant with fewer rays for legibility
Apple touch icon	Done	180x180
LinkedIn banner	Done	1584x396, lockup centred on navy with amber accent lines
Email signature block	Done	2560x1440 AI-rendered with lockup, divider, and thedesk.global

AI-rendered lockups (high-res)	Done	Dark and light at 2560x1440, Playfair Display type, correct spelling
Brand guidelines document	This document	Version 2.0, fully updated

13. Naming Conventions

Names earn their keep when they sound like they were there all along.

Existing patterns: Today (the home page, not "Home" or "Dashboard"). Archive (paginated history, not "All stories"). Edition (one issue, numbered, never "Issue"). Today's topics (rail card). Today in brief (scan strip). Where things stand (macro). Partner angles (the four-line block). Why this matters, Key takeaway, What to watch (topic deep-dive labels). Editor's letter (the long-form narrative). Ruben's Take (apostrophe-s, never "Editor's Note"). Topic deck. Dates to watch. Market stress.

Rules for naming the next thing:

Rule	Example
Plain English noun phrase, two or three words	"Topic deck" not "Story grid"
Newsroom register, not product-speak	"Dates to watch" not "Upcoming Events Module"
Present tense, declarative	"Where things stand" not "How things are trending"
Possessive when authored	"Ruben's Take", "Editor's letter"
Title Case for page names and panel headers	Sentence case for overlines
Australian English always	colour, behaviour, organisation, realise

Avoid by construction: "Dashboard", "Hub", "Center", "Insights" (overloaded), "Smart" anything, "AI-powered" anything.

14. Elevator Pitch

For external use, the canonical description of The Desk:

The Desk is a daily intelligence briefing for professionals in the Australian property partner channel. It delivers the morning's most important stories with ready-to-use talking points for institutional partners, brokers, advisers and buyer's agents. Written by Ruben Laubscher, Head of Partnerships at InvestorKit.

Short form (under 30 words): Daily intelligence for property partners. The stories that matter, the angles that win the call. Written by Ruben Laubscher at InvestorKit.

One-liner (under 15 words): The morning briefing that wins the 10am call.

If a rule here conflicts with code, code wins. Fix the doc.